When to Use Universal Precautions

Universal precautions are part of general infection control. Blood borne pathogens are most often transferred through exposure to blood. But this can also happen when you come into contact with other body fluids. You should use universal precautions when you come into contact with any of the body fluids in column one.

Body fluids where universal precautions DO apply:	**Body fluids where universal precautions DO NOT apply: (meaning there is no risk of bloodborne pathogen infection unless there is blood present in these fluids):**
– Blood.	– Saliva.
– Body fluids containing visible blood.	– Sweat.
– Semen and vaginal secretions.	– Feces or stool.
– Joint fluid.	– Nasal secretions.
– Brain and spinal cord fluid.	– Tears.
– Fluid around the lungs.	– Urine.
– Fluid around the heart.	– Vomit.
– Fluid surrounding the intestines.	– Sputum. This is fluid from lungs that is produced when you cough or clear your throat.
– Fluid that surrounds the fetus in a woman's uterus.	
– Breast milk.	

***While it is sometimes difficult, if not impossible to know or recognize the difference between different types of body fluids, or to know if blood is (or will be) present in the body fluid, many organizations recommend that all body fluids should be considered potentially infectious and therefore universal precautions should be considered for use when there is a likelihood of contact with the body fluids on the list in column 2 as well.**

It is also important to prevent infections that can spread in ways other than blood and body fluids. Use general infection control procedures to prevent infections that spread by:
– Air. An example is chicken pox.
– Large droplets. Examples include coughing, talking, or sneezing.
– Skin contact. Examples include herpes simplex virus.